"Bengaluru was called the garden city earlier...25 years back, we had 70 lakh people living here, now we have 1.4 crore. Last year, we saw 7,000 borewells drying up...now I'm trying to fix the water bodies, rejuvenate the water table. We'll change the image of Bengaluru"

- D.K. SHIVAKUMAR, *Deputy Chief Minister, Karnataka*



ESHWAR KHANDRE
Minister of Forest, Ecology and Environment, Karnataka

"We are planting 30 million saplings this year and about 70 million in 2026. Our aim is to improve the forest green cover of the state from around 21-22% now to 25% by the end of 2028"

ment. Top on his agenda is a comprehensive plan to change the city's image as a metropolis struggling with traffic congestion and water shortages. Pointing out that Bengaluru, with a population of 14 million, is home to 11 million vehicles, Shivakumar said: "We plan to spend almost Rs 80,000-100,000 crore on urban development in Bengaluru." Apart from new flyovers and metro rail lines, the focus is also on augmenting the city's water supply network through the Cauvery 6th Stage scheme—which is currently in the drawing board stage—and finalising the location for a second greenfield airport for Bengaluru.

In his keynote address, Khandre said the push has been towards increasing the state's forest cover through an afforestation drive, cracking down on forest land encroachment and pursuing sustainable practices both in the agriculture-dependent rural parts and the ever-expanding urban agglomerations. The goal, says Khandre, is to increase the forest cover to 25 per cent of the state's total geographical area by 2028 from around 22 per cent at present. "We must balance economic growth with environmental sustainability by addressing key risks such as pollution, resource overuse and waste management," said Khandre, adding that Karnataka achieved a good score of 75 on the sustainable development goals (SDG) index for the year 2023-24. The overall SDG score for the country was 71 during the same period.

Karnataka is also home to one-fourth of India's elephant population and has the second largest tiger count in the country after Madhya Pradesh. The conclave featured tiger biologists, elephant researchers and senior forest department officials who analysed the pressing problems relating to human-animal conflict and wildlife conservation. A corresponding view came from four legislators hailing from the districts of Kodagu, Shivamogga and Mysuru where human-animal conflict has been rising—most visibly in the phenomenon of wild elephant herds that are now permanent residents of plantations in the Western Ghats region. As wildlife biologist Ravi Chellam noted, "The fact is, for many species, up to 50 per cent, even 60 per cent,